Root Cause Analysis

Dig beneath a recurring problem with a fishbone and 5 Whys, check the cause, and test a fix.

Improve · Fishbone (Ishikawa) Diagram · 5 Whys · Fix the System, Not the Person

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 14 May

1 The Problem

FACTS, NOT BLAME

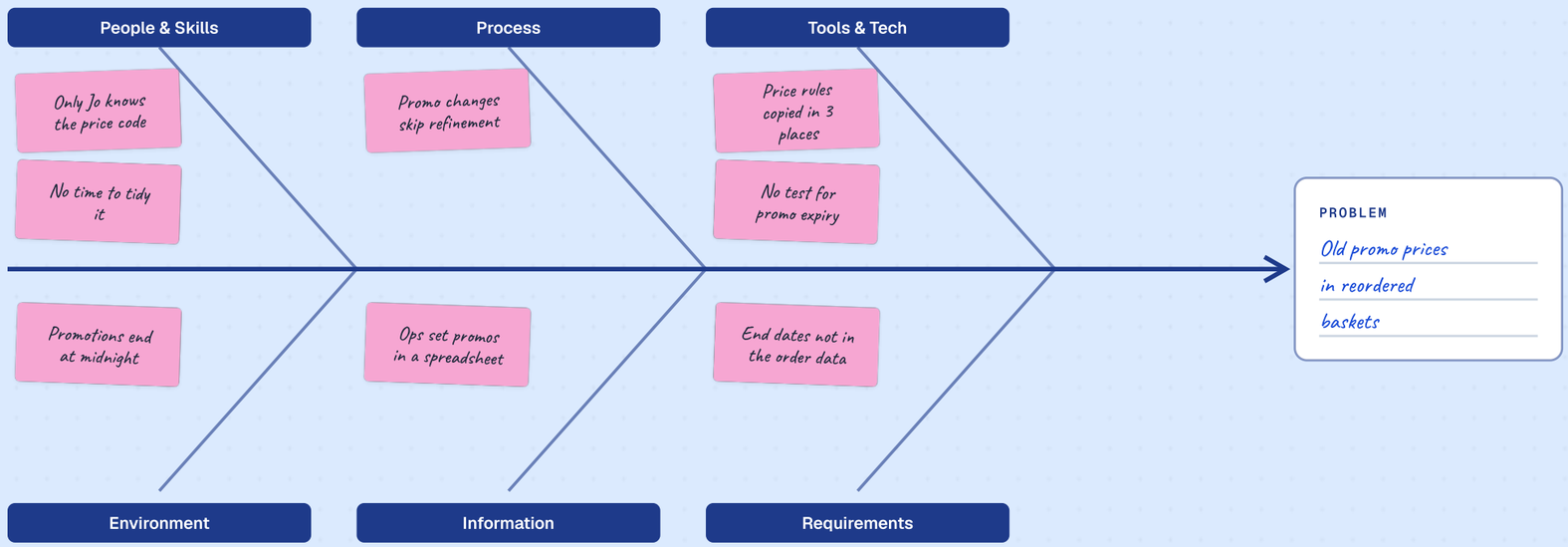
What happened: reordered baskets show old promotion prices

When, where, how often: after a promotion ends; 5 times in April

Impact: refunds, complaints, and 2 days of fixes each time

2 Fishbone

STICKIES ON THE BONE THEY BELONG TO



3 5 Whys

ASK WHY UNTIL YOU REACH A CAUSE YOU CAN FIX

Why 1? Why does the basket keep the old price?
it copies the price from the last order

↓

Why 2? Why doesn't it re-check the price?
the reorder path has its own price rules

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Why 3? Why its own rules?
copied in a hurry to hit the March launch

↓

Why 4? Why wasn't it caught?
no test covers a promotion ending

↓

Why 5? Why no test?
nobody owns pricing, so nobody adds them

Root cause: price rules copied, with no owner and no tests

4 Check the Cause

BEFORE YOU FIX IT

- [x] If we fixed this, would the problem stop?
- [x] Do we have evidence, not just opinion?
- [x] Is it about the system, not a person?
- [x] Is it within our control or influence?
- [x] Would it explain other problems too?

Any "no"? Ask why again, or test another branch.

5 Countermeasures

SMALL, TESTABLE FIXES

ACTION	OWNER	BY WHEN
One shared price service for every path	Jo	Sprint 20
Tests for promotion start and end	Ravi	Sprint 19
Pricing gets a named owner	Priya	this week	

6 Did It Work?

We'll measure: wrong-price complaints a month

Baseline: 5 in April

Check on: end of June

Result: 0 in June

- [x] Fixed
- [ ] Better
- [ ] No change

"Why does this keep happening, and what in our system lets it?"

"If we fixed the cause, what else would get better?"

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Systems-Thinking · Continuous Improvement · Team-Led Change